

THE CODEX CONCORDANCE

Where the fifteen creatures of Kwaidan would sit in the six classes of Codex Bestiarium — and why not one of them is already in it.

This edition belongs to a shelf. Codex Bestiarium is Valice Press's reference volume of a hundred and twelve creatures from forty traditions, sorted into six classes by what the creature is for rather than by where it lives. Readers arrive at Hearn from it, and the obvious thing to print here would be a list of the creatures the two books share.

There are none. Not one of the fifteen creatures and apparitions in this book appears among the Codex's hundred and twelve, and that is the useful fact rather than an embarrassing one. The Codex gives Japan three entries — the tengu of the mountains, the kappa of the rivers, and Yamata-no-Orochi, the eight-headed serpent — and all three have bodies, addresses and a shape a reader can picture before reading a word. Kwaidan has almost none of that. What Hearn collected is the other half of the Japanese record: the dead who will not go, the thing on the road with no face, the wife who is a snowstorm, the woman who is a willow. The two books are not rivals for the same shelf-space. They are the two halves of one subject.

The sharpest case is the class the Codex calls The Restless Dead. It is the smallest class in that book — eight entries, from eight traditions, the Norse draugr to the Andean Supay — and Japan is not one of the eight. Five of the fifteen below would go straight into it. Hearn is where Japan's answer to that question actually is.

The table places each of this book's fifteen where the Codex's own scheme would put it. Two of them cannot be placed, and the reason is worth a line: the Codex classifies creatures, and Kwaidan contains a bell and an island that behave like creatures without being any. That is a fair description of what makes the collection strange.

Codex Bestiarium: 112 Legendary Creatures from 40 Traditions is at valicepress.com. The companion sheet for this book carries the same table on one page, with the Codex's six classes printed in full.

The six classes of the Codex

Class	What it collects	From this book
I · The Guardians	Things stationed where passage is possible and permission is not.	—
II · The Devourers	Hunger, personified: man-eaters, child-stealers, blood-drinkers.	Jikininki; Rokuro-kubi
III · The Shape-Changeers	Things that are not what they appear to be.	Tree-spirit (Ubazakura); Noppera-bō; Yuki-onna; Willow-spirit (Aoyagi); Tree-substitution; Ant-kingdom
IV · The Water-Dwellers	What nineteen traditions made of drowning.	—
V · Sky and Storm	Thunder, given a body.	—
VI · The Restless Dead	The dead who did not go.	Heiké ghosts; Oshidori spirit; Rebirth (tenshō); Onryō (threatened); Unfinished dead
Unclassified	Not creatures. The Codex has no class for a bell or an island.	Cursed bell / Mugen-Kané; Hōrai

VI · THE RESTLESS DEAD. Five. The class Japan is missing from in the Codex, and the class this book is mostly made of. Note how little they resemble the Codex's other eight: the draugr is heavier than a man and fights; a

Roman lemur has no face and no name. Hearn's dead are polite, and they want something specific.

II · THE DEVOURERS. Two, and both are literal. The jikininki is a gaki, a hungry ghost condemned to eat corpses. The rokuro-kubi of this book are man-eaters and say so out loud — “when we shall have eaten him, our bellies will be well filled”. The rokuro-kubi has relatives in the Codex and Japan is the missing member of the family: the Siamese krasue, the Vietnamese ma lai and the Filipino manananggal are all detachable creatures whose head, or upper half, leaves the body at night and comes back before dawn. The Codex's own Krasue entry says so in terms — the glow “separates this creature from its relatives elsewhere”, and it names “the Vietnamese and Filipino versions”. It could not name a Japanese one, because the Japanese member of the family is here. (All three sit in the Codex's kin family C, which it defines by a different resemblance — the night predator of mothers and newborns — so the family label is not the link; the detachable body is.)

III · THE SHAPE-CHANGERS. Six. The Codex's Japanese entry in this class is the tengu, which changes its own shape. Hearn's six change what a thing is — a road, a wife, a tree, a lifetime — which is the same fear taken one step further in.

UNCLASSIFIED. Two that will not go in. One is an object and one is a place, and both act. The Codex has no class for them because a reference book of creatures cannot have one, and a reader who wants to know why Kwaïdan feels different from a bestiary can start here.

From Kwaïdan: Stories and Studies of Strange Things, Valice Classics 13. Free at valicepress.com/companion/kwaïdan